WAR IN THE MEDITERRANEAN

ITALY'S ENTRY INTO THE WAR in June 1940 initiated a three-year naval struggle for control of the Mediterranean. The Italian navy, the Regia Marina, fought bravely, although its effectiveness was limited by lack of radar. When the Italians were joined by the land-based aircraft of the German Luftwaffe, Britain's Royal Navy came under severe pressure. Running convoys from Alexandria and Gibraltar to Malta, a key British base less than 62 miles (100 km) from Sicily, was always difficult and sometimes impossible. Although British victories at Taranto and Cape Matapan weakened the Italian fleet, the Royal Navy's losses were grievous, mostly to air attack but also to German and Italian submarines. By the start of 1942 the Axis was winning control of the Mediterranean. The progress of Allied ground forces in North Africa, facilitated by naval attacks on Axis supply ships, eventually relieved the pressure on sea communications. Italy was defeated in September 1943.

THE MEDITERRANEAN THEATER 1940–1943

By 1942 the Mediterranean was in danger of becoming an Axis lake. The Germans had invaded Greece in 1941, and by October 1942 British land forces had been driven back almost to Alexandria. Yet the Royal Navy continued to operate, escorting convoys to isolated Malta. The situation changed in November 1942 with the Allied victory in Egypt and US landings in Algeria.

KEY

- Under Allied control Jul 1940
- Under Axis control Jul 1940
- Vichy French possessions
- Axis airbase
- Main British convoy routes
- Main Axis convoy routes
- Allied victory
- Axis victory
- Inconclusive action



WORLD WAR II

MERS-EL-KEBIR



Date July 3, 1940
Forces British: 1 carrier, 2 battleships, 1 battlecruiser, 2 light cruisers, 11 destroyers; French: 4 battleships, 6 destroyers, 5 submarines
Losses British: none; French: 3 battleships sunk or disabled
Location West of Oran, French Algeria

As German forces overran France in June 1940, the French Navy made vigorous efforts to keep its warships out of Nazi hands. Ships dispersed to British ports and the French overseas empire, including Mers-el-Kebir in French Algeria. The armistice terms agreed on June 24 specified that the French Navy would not be handed over to the Germans. The British, however, did not trust Germany or France to stick to the agreement. The addition of the French fleet to the Axis naval forces would have dangerously altered the balance of power at sea. Britain decided to ensure this could never happen. A force consisting of the battlecruiser *Hood*, the battleships *Valiant* and *Resolution*, and the carrier *Ark Royal* was sent to Mers-el-Kebir. Its commander, Admiral Sir James Somerville, had orders to demand that the French either join the British war effort, surrender their ships into British hands, or sail to internment in the Americas. If they refused these options they had to scuttle their ships or be fired upon. The French commander in Mers-el-Kebir, Admiral Marcel Gensoul, preferred to fight. He cleared his four battleships—*Dunkerque*, *Strasbourg*, *Bretagne*, and *Provence*—for action and attempted to get under way. The British gunnery was accurate and destruction swift. *Bretagne* was hit by 15-inch salvoes, exploded and capsized, *Dunkerque* was immobilized, and *Provence* set on fire and forced to beach. Only *Strasbourg* escaped to Toulon, but she was scuttled along with the rest of the Vichy fleet in 1942 to prevent her falling into Germans hands. Almost 1,300 French sailors died at Mers-el-Kebir, an action regretted by the Royal Navy and bitterly resented in France.

French fleet at Mers-el-Kebir
A French soldier stands guard next to the battleships *Dunkerque* and *Strasbourg*. The sister ships were of an unusual design with all their main guns mounted forward.



WORLD WAR II

CALABRIA



Date July 9, 1940
Forces British: 1 carrier, 3 battleships, 5 cruisers, 16 destroyers; Italians: 2 battleships, 14 cruisers, 16 destroyers
Losses none
Location East of Punta Stilo, Calabria

One month after Italy had entered the war, a British naval force under Admiral Sir Andrew Cunningham escorting convoys from Alexandria to Malta was intercepted by Italian warships under Admiral Inigo Campioni. The British had suffered damage in attacks by Italian land-based aircraft, leading the Italians to believe they were in worse shape than was actually the case. After a clash between opposing cruisers, Cunningham's flagship *Warspite* dueled at maximum range with the Italian battleships *Giulio Cesare* and *Conte di Cavour*. *Warspite* hit *Giulio Cesare* with a 15-in shell from a distance of 15 miles (24 km), causing considerable damage. As the other British battleships, *Malaya* and *Royal Sovereign*, came up the Italians turned for home. The Italian air force concluded the engagement by bombing both fleets indiscriminately.